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***Women
can also
benefit from
specialised
leadership
development
programmes***

B-schools Must Promote Gender Equality

**These institutes should enable women to lead
by collaborating with industry to offer mentorship,
scholarships and networking opportunities**

AS WE TRY to harness India's rapid economic growth potential, it is also pertinent to take note of the widespread gender disparity that has led to the country being ranked 140 among the 156 countries in the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report, 2021. It is estimated that less than 9 per cent of Indian businesses have women as top leaders and the percentage of female board members in listed companies is a meagre 15.9 per cent. Considering that women make up nearly half of the country's population, this imbalance is glaring and needs urgent attention from all stakeholders.

When I joined IIM Calcutta, the representation of women was relatively low compared to men. Out of the 150-odd students in my batch, only seven to 10 were women. Despite the imbalance, there were positive dynamics within the class, as everyone interacted well and was comfortable with each other. However, during the placement process, there were still limitations on the types of companies willing to hire women and the specific roles offered to them. Fortunately, in recent years, there has been a noticeable shift, leading to an improvement in women's representation. However, there is still work to be done to ensure gender parity in B-schools. India's leading B-schools have the potential to lead the way in eliminating gender disparity. As someone who has been a Co-founder and Chairperson of multiple ventures, I can vouch for the importance of creating an inclusive environment where women feel empowered to take on leadership roles. This environment can be built by ensuring access through collaborations between B-schools and the industry, to introduce mentorship programmes, scholarships and networking opportunities, specifically for women. These initiatives would encourage more women to join and aim for leadership roles.

When I started my entrepreneurial journey, there were a lot of lessons and leadership skills that I eventually acquired in the process. Similarly, many women leaders who have reached where they are today through their own learning curves would have further shortened their growth timelines, if they were given the opportunity to nurture their leadership skills and confidence during the academic years. B-schools can change the scenario by designing leadership development programmes that draw from the experiences of women business leaders and help young talent understand and overcome the unique challenges that only